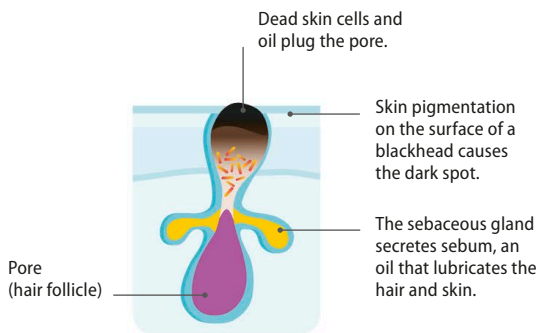


Pimples

Pimples occur when dead skin cells and oil clog the pores of the skin. Also known as acne or zits, pimples can make teens feel self-conscious, but they are a normal part of growing up.

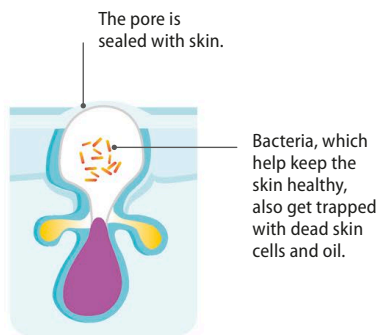
▷ Blackheads

When a plug of dead skin cells and oil clogs up a pore, it is called a blackhead. A blackhead is not filled with dirt—rather, the dark spot is caused by skin pigmentation. It can contain bacteria.



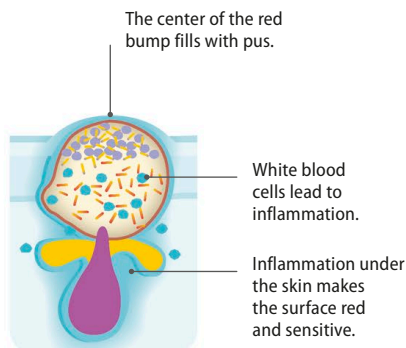
▷ Whiteheads

Whiteheads happen when a thin membrane of skin traps a plug of dead skin cells, oil, and bacteria. They can get bigger as the sebaceous gland continues to produce oil, which builds up underneath the skin.



▷ Pustules

These red bumps with a pus-filled center are what most people think of when they think of acne. They appear when there is an infection of the pore, which causes pus to form.



SEE ALSO

◀ 60–61 Keeping clean

◀ 62–63 Sweat and smells

Healthy eating

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Body image

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Acne

Acne is the umbrella term for minor outbreaks of blackheads, whiteheads, and other types of pimples. Acne begins when pores (hair follicles) get blocked by dead skin cells and oil (sebum). It can help to know what type of acne a teen has in order to treat it effectively.

MYTH BUSTER

The truth about pimples

Poor diet doesn't cause skin problems.

No foods cause acne, but eating healthfully can help to prevent it.

Pimples aren't caused by uncleanliness.

Pimples start beneath the skin's surface, so aren't caused by a lack of washing.

Menstruation may lead to pimples.

Changing hormone levels before and during a period have only a minor impact, but this tends to be temporary.

Infection

When bacteria build up in a blackhead or whitehead, it can lead to infection. The body's immune system then sends in white blood cells to attack the infection, which causes the redness and swelling that makes pimples painful.

There are four types of pimples that can develop: papules, pustules, nodules, and cysts. Papules and pustules are red bumps, with pustules having pus-filled tips. Nodules and cysts are larger and form deep under the skin. Nodules are solid, while cysts are liquid-filled.